

Q My baby is plumper than other babies the same age. Am I overfeeding her?

It's likely that you just have a plump baby on your hands. Your baby will double her body weight in the first three months. Until she is on the move, her sedentary lifestyle means that her muscles are yet to develop and she will gain a covering of fat.

Some babies are naturally bigger—much is dependent on genetics. Any differences usually iron out by toddlerhood. However, with a global rise in obesity, it's worth being aware of potential pitfalls of weight gain.

Formula-fed babies

A cohort of studies shows that breast-fed babies tend to be leaner, largely because they tend to stop drinking milk when they've had their

fill. If your baby is formula fed, be careful that you are paying attention to her "full-up" cues. It may be tempting to encourage her to finish a bottle, but if she loses interest in a feeding before the end, perhaps becoming restless and turning her head, she is signaling that her tummy is full. When parents ignore these natural cues, however well intentioned, they are encouraging a habit of overeating that can continue throughout childhood and beyond.

TIPS FOR A HEALTHY BABY WEIGHT

Don't become too focused on your baby's weight, but do be aware of the following guidelines:

» **Regular checkups:** your pediatrician can check your baby's weight and length charts and advise you if they think there is a concern. If your baby has moved up two percentiles on her growth chart, this could flag a weight issue that needs attention.

» **Sleep:** getting enough sleep is linked to a healthy metabolism and weight control; at three months, your baby needs around 15 hours of sleep a day, so putting healthy sleep routines in place is important.

» **Starting solids correctly:** starting solids before four to six months has been shown to adversely affect weight, so don't be in a hurry to get your baby onto baby rice. When you do start solids, introduce plenty of fruit and vegetable purées among the rice and cereals.



Little and large Babies' weights can differ by several pounds from birth, and being above or below average weight is perfectly normal.

Q Should I be concerned that my child is lagging behind others of the same age in our baby group?

The rate at which babies reach certain milestones can vary enormously. Socializing with parents who have babies of the same age is beneficial, but it can make you anxious as to whether your baby is doing everything she should be doing for her age and stage.

The truth is that while babies follow the same developmental progression, they do so at their own pace. Your baby develops in four areas: physically; verbally; socially; and cognitively. Learning in one area is often linked

to skill acquisition in another arena. But often, a certain skill set takes a back seat while your baby spends time concentrating on something else. For example, while one baby may tirelessly swipe at objects on her play mat, another may be concentrating on the new noises she can make, fascinated by the coos and gurgles she is producing. Eventually both babies will build muscle strength and develop their communication skills.

As long as your baby has the opportunities and stimulation to learn new skills, often the actual learning of a new skill is more important than the time frame for when the skill is mastered. For example, if a developmental chart suggests your baby will walk between 12 and 15 months, and she doesn't take her first step

until 17 months, this doesn't mean that there is a problem. If you are concerned about any aspect of your baby's development, always seek advice and reassurance from your baby's pediatrician.

If you have twin babies, try not to compare their development too closely. Remember, they are individuals and will each develop at their own rate.